

Ohio State - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	The preseason national-title favorite on the strongest underlying profile in the field.
Preseason consensus	No. 1, 1,672 points, 40 first-place votes · No. 1
Returning production	60% (No. 33) overall · Off. 71% (No. 8) · Def. 49% (No. 78)
Primer power rating	+32.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	10.2 wins · most likely 10-2
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ - Similar championship-level quality.
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: Arthur Smith's offense should be built around QB Julian Sayin's efficiency and WR Jeremiah Smith's matchup dominance, with RB Bo Jackson and a veteran interior line giving Ohio State a credible run/play-action complement rather than forcing the passing game to carry every down.

Bottom line: Ohio State is the most defensible preseason No. 1 because the offense returns the quarterback, premier receiving talent and interior-line core of an elite efficiency unit; the championship question is whether a defense with only 49% returning production can stay near its historic 2025 standard rather than merely remain very good.

Beats expectations if: QB Sayin and WR Jeremiah Smith preserve elite passing efficiency, Arthur Smith adds enough run/play-action multiplicity to improve the No. 72 rushing profile, and the transfer-heavy defensive reload keeps Patricia near top-five efficiency despite losing so many pros.

Disappoints if: The new offensive play-caller disrupts an elite passing formula, tackle uncertainty creates too much pressure, and the rebuilt defensive front/linebacker group slips enough to force shootouts.

Five things to remember

- 1 National baseline:** Ohio State is No. 1 in both final preseason SP+ (+32.7) and the AP poll, with SP+ No. 2 offense and No. 1 defense.
- 2 2025 baseline:** QB Julian Sayin returns as the established QB1 after a 2025 offense that ranked No. 2 in pass efficiency, No. 2 on third down, No. 4 in EPA/play and No. 1 in success rate.
- 3 ★ WR Jeremiah Smith:** WR Jeremiah Smith is a first-team AP/Walter Camp preseason All-American and the defining skill player in an offense returning 71% of production (No. 8).
- 4 Returning production:** The 2025 defense was No. 1 in scoring, total and opponent-adjusted defense, but 2026 defensive returning production is only 49% (No. 78).
- 5 Coaching:** OC Arthur Smith is the primary offensive play-caller; DC Matt Patricia returns, but the exact defensive game-day play-caller remains unresolved.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	12-2 (9-1 Big Ten)	● Excellent
Scoring	33.4 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	422.6 YPG	● Very good
Rush offense	154.4 YPG · 4.5 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	9.20 YPA · 33 TD / 8 INT	● Elite
Third downs	53.3%	● Elite
Scoring defense	9.3 PPG allowed	● Elite
Total defense	219.1 YPG allowed	● Elite
Rush defense	89.4 YPG · 2.9 YPC	● Elite
Pass defense	129.7 YPG · 5.31 YPA · 7 TD allowed	● Elite

The 2025 team was not merely talented; it was efficient on both sides, especially down-to-down.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+14.32 · No. 1	● Elite
Off. EPA/play	+0.272 · No. 4	● Elite
Off. success rate	55.2% · No. 1	● Elite
Off. explosive-play rate	12.7% · No. 54	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	11.1% · No. 9	● Elite
Opp.-adjusted defense	+14.91 · No. 1	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.290 · No. 2	● Elite
Def. success rate allowed	33.8% · No. 8	● Elite
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	6.6% · No. 1	● Elite
Havoc created	17.3% · No. 30	● Very good

Advanced-stat read: Ohio State was elite in every opponent-adjusted/play-efficiency category that matters most: No. 1 adjusted offense, No. 4 offensive EPA, No. 1 offensive success, No. 1 adjusted defense, No. 2 defensive EPA and No. 1 explosive-play prevention.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Ryan Day - returning	● ↑ Program/QB infrastructure remains a major stabilizer while Day intentionally moves further toward a CEO role around the offense.
OC / primary offensive play-caller	◆ Arthur Smith - new external	● ↔ A veteran external play-caller inherits elite QB/receiver efficiency and brings TE movement, wide/outside-zone and play-action ideas.
DC / co-DC-secondary	Matt Patricia / Tim Walton - returning	● ↑ Defensive-system continuity is valuable during a personnel reload.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Ja’Kobi Jackson	Florida	● ↔ Meaningful rotational/competition addition behind RB Bo Jackson.
◆ WR Devin McCuin	UTSA	● ↔ Current third-WR frontrunner; useful answer to receiver attrition but the role remains open.
◆ TE Hunter Welcing	Northwestern	● ↔ Mackey-recognized transfer adds a major-role option to a room replacing NFL tight ends.

Out	To	Loss
WR Carnell Tate	NFL (Tennessee), Round 1, No. 4	● ↓ Elite receiver loss to the NFL.
TE Max Klare	NFL (L.A. Rams), Round 2, No. 61	● ↓ Major tight-end production/experience leaves.
TE Will Kacmarek	NFL (Miami), Round 3, No. 87	● ↓ Second professional tight-end loss increases dependence on a reworked room.
OL Ethan Onianwa	NFL (Atlanta), Round 7, No. 231	● ↔ Veteran line loss is mitigated by three established interior returners.
OL Tegra Tshabola	Kentucky	● ↔ Material line departure adds to tackle/best-five uncertainty.

Offensive net: ● ↔ Elite QB/skill talent remains, but multiple NFL losses and tackle turnover reduce continuity.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DT James Smith	Alabama	● ↑ High-upside top-rotation interior addition directly addressing major defensive-tackle losses.
◆ DE Qua Russaw	Alabama	● ↑ Top-group edge addition next to DE Kenyatta Jackson Jr.
◆ LB Christian Alliegro	Wisconsin	● ↔ Veteran top-group linebacker candidate in a room replacing two top-10 NFL picks.
◆ SAF Earl Little Jr.	Florida State	● ↑ Projected starting safety with Bednarik/Thorpe recognition.

Out	To	Loss
LB Arvell Reese	NFL (N.Y. Giants), Round 1, No. 5	● ↓ Top-five draft pick and high-leverage linebacker production leaves.
LB Sonny Styles	NFL (Washington), Round 1, No. 7	● ↓ Second top-10 linebacker loss compounds the reset around LB Payton Pierce.
S Caleb Downs	NFL (Dallas), Round 1, No. 11	● ↓ Elite safety loss raises the replacement bar even with a talented 2026 secondary.
DT Kayden McDonald	NFL (Houston), Round 2, No. 36	● ↓ Major interior loss from the No. 1 defense.
CB Davison Igbinosun	NFL (Buffalo), Round 2, No. 62	● ↓ Starting-corner caliber loss, partly offset by Mathews/Sanchez and portal depth.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Five major NFL losses, including three first-rounders, create a substantial continuity reset despite high-end replacements.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Efficient, quarterback-driven attack centered on QB Julian Sayin and WR Jeremiah Smith.	Elite 2025 pass efficiency, third downs, EPA/play and success rate.	Run-game/explosive complement plus tackle, WR3 and TE transitions.
Defense	DC Matt Patricia's flexible defense still has edge/coverage talent.	Elite returning talent and a historically dominant 2025 efficiency baseline.	DT, LB and nickel after massive NFL attrition.
Special teams	Transition unit with P Joe McGuire returning while kicker and long snapper change.	Punter continuity.	New kicker/long snapper and SP+ special teams No. 67.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● A	● ↔	High	QB Julian Sayin returns with national recognition after leading an elite 2025 passing offense.
RB	● A-	● ↔	Medium-high	RB Bo Jackson returns as the lead back with a deep supporting rotation.
WR	● A+	● ↔	High	WR Jeremiah Smith is a first-team All-American and WR Brandon Inniss adds proven continuity.
TE	● B	● ↓	Medium	TE Nate Roberts and TE Hunter Welcing provide options after two 2025 tight ends reached the NFL draft.
OL	● A-	● ↔	Medium-high	OL Luke Montgomery, C Carson Hinzman and OL Austin Siereveld form an unusually strong interior core.
DL/Edge	● A-	● ↓	Medium	EDGE Kenyatta Jackson Jr. anchors a talented reload after major professional departures.
LB	● B+	● ↓	Medium	LB Payton Pierce anchors a group replacing major production from LB Arvell Reese and LB Sonny Styles.
Secondary	● A-	● ↓	Medium-high	A strong returning corner/safety core must replace S Caleb Downs and other professional departures.
Special teams	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	P Joe McGuire returns, but kicker and long snapper change; SP+ ranks the unit No. 67.
Coaching	● A	● ↔	Medium-high	HC Ryan Day and DC Matt Patricia provide continuity while OC Arthur Smith is a high-level addition.
Overall	● A+	● ↔	Medium-high	No. 1 SP+, No. 1 AP and championship-level QB/WR/OL talent outweigh the defensive reload risk.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Jeremiah Smith	WR	● National superstar / matchup-defining WR	AP first team · Walter Camp first team · Big Ten preseason honoree · Biletnikoff · Maxwell	The offense can remain elite through coordinator change because WR Jeremiah Smith remains the defining matchup problem.
Julian Sayin	QB	● Elite returning QB1	Walter Camp second team · Big Ten preseason honoree · Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	QB Julian Sayin's continuity gives Ohio State an unusually high floor through the OC change.
Luke Montgomery	OL	● Nationally recognized interior-line anchor	AP second team · Outland	One of three established interior pieces protecting Sayin while tackle combinations settle.
Austin Siereveld	OL	● Nationally recognized guard	Walter Camp first team · Outland	Pairs with Montgomery/Hinzman to give the offense an elite interior floor.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Bo Jackson	RB	● High-end returning lead back	Doak Walker · Maxwell	A stronger RB Bo Jackson-led run game would give the elite passing offense another answer.
Kenyatta Jackson Jr.	DE	● Returning edge anchor	Bednarik · Nagurski	The defensive reload needs a proven front-seven star.
Payton Pierce	LB	● Defensive communication anchor	-	Central returner in the linebacker room replacing two top-seven NFL picks.
Jaylen McClain	SAF	● Returning safety/captain	Nagurski	The secondary needs continuity after Caleb Downs and multiple pro departures.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Brutal for a title favorite: Ball State/Kent State/Northwestern provide breathers, but Ohio State travels to Texas, Iowa, Indiana, USC and Nebraska.
Difficulty	● 10/10 · SP+ SOS No. 3
Hardest stretch	at Indiana -> bye -> at USC -> Oregon
Swing games	at Texas, at Indiana, Oregon
Advantage	The two softest early home games bracket the Texas trip, and the late Michigan game is at home.
Expected	10.2 wins; likely 10-2
Floor / ceiling	9-3 / 12-0

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Ohio State will be priced like the consensus No. 1 team.
Back them when	Facing opponents that cannot pressure the tackle uncertainty or cover WR Jeremiah Smith/WR Brandon Inniss without sacrificing the run fit.
Fade/pass when	Laying an extreme premium against elite offenses before the new DT/LB/nickel groups prove 2025-level efficiency, or when the price assumes the No. 1 defense carries over unchanged.
Key monitor	Final tackle/best-five OL, Third WR winner, DT/LB/nickel competition, Exact defensive play-calling designation, New kicker/long snapper performance
Week 1 baseline	Ohio State -59.5 vs. Ball State - Ohio State primer +32.5 minus Ball State SP+ proxy -25.1 plus 2.0 home field = 59.6, rounded to -59.5; no matchup/availability adjustment. Live market: Ohio State -50.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Ohio State enters 2026 as the clearest preseason No. 1: QB Julian Sayin, WR Jeremiah Smith and an elite interior OL keep the offense championship-ready even with OC Arthur Smith taking over play-calling. The run-game ceiling and tackle configuration are the main offensive variables.

The larger question is defensive reload speed after a massive professional departure class and only 49% returning production. The baseline remains **10.2 wins · most likely 10-2**, but a brutal road schedule makes pass protection and front-seven replacement production the key title-level tests.

About this primer

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Sources: [NFL departures](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [camp update](#) · [coaching update](#) · [Eleven Warriors report](#) · [camp update](#) · [Eleven Warriors report](#) · [C.J. Hicks 2026 roster bio](#) · [Bryson Rodgers 2026 roster bio](#) · [camp update](#)

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